



GPay to go the NFC route?

According to reports, Google Pay has started testing out NFC-based card payments in India. <http://digit.in/sep20-13>



"Flip to silence" for non-Pixels

Google Phone app starts rolling out the "Flip to Silence" feature to non-Pixel devices. <http://digit.in/sep20-14>

OnePlus Nord

The pragmatic choice

The OnePlus Nord is a smartphone that's cheap and just works. At ₹29,999, the beefed-up 12GB RAM variant we received for review is compact for today's standards, but underneath it's a well-oiled machine that's tuned to get the job done. So, how does the OnePlus Nord shape up? Let's find out.

Design and display

The OnePlus Nord's size is smaller than the OnePlus 8, but it's also wider, because it had to maintain the 20:9 aspect ratio. The Nord also gets the physical alert slider on the right, and thanks to the small size, left handers can also reach it with ease. Also, the front and rear panel are reinforced with Gorilla Glass 5, the frame itself is polished plastic.

We like that the display glass is not curved along the edges, since it minimises the chances of accidental taps. The panel is also HDR10+ certified and hits 820 nits in peak brightness and 8 nits at its lowest.

Camera performance

OnePlus built up a lot of hype around the camera, but the spec-sheet is simply the same as what you'd expect on a mid-range phone. That includes an OIS-stabilised Sony IMX586 48MP camera, along with an 8MP ultrawide lens, and two 2MP cameras for macro and portrait shots, which is pretty standard.

The camera feels well-tuned but not extraordinarily good. The details are what you'd expect from a 48MP camera, and the colour reproduction is quite natural. The Nightscape mode is also quite well tuned and images look sharp in lowlight. Portraits come out a little softer on details but gets the colours quite right.

Software

We were excited to try out OxygenOS decoupled from a flagship processor



for the first time. OxygenOS on the OnePlus Nord is the same as the OnePlus 8 and the OnePlus 8 Pro. Every little feature that's there on the 8 and 8 Pro, is also there on the Nord. All of it works just as well as it does on its flagship devices. Speed, customisations, and minimalist aesthetics are all ensured, even with a slower processor in hand. The bugs that are present on the OnePlus 8 Pro are ironed out in this one. The 8 Pro still freezes while browsing apps like Instagram, Facebook or Chrome. The Nord has no such issues.

Performance

The OnePlus Nord may not have the best silicon inside, but it feels just as fast as its flagship siblings launched this year. A lot of the credit goes to the Snapdragon 765G. When compared the phone against the best mid-rangers before it, the OnePlus Nord is indeed ahead, but only by around 10-12 per cent in benchmark scores. Which isn't groundbreaking for this segment, like how the Snapdragon 730 was last year.

We also ran a CPU throttling test. The Nord fared well on this test with the CPU only throttling to 89 per cent of its performance during 30 minutes.

However, we can't really say the OnePlus Nord is cut out for gaming.

The compact form factor is particularly a hindrance to high-octane gaming. You have less space for your button layout and even lesser space to nail the aim. The touch response, on the other hand, is really good. So while the form factor is geared towards non-gamers, you can get the gaming performance you desire, should you choose to.

Battery life

The 4115mAh battery isn't the best feature of the smartphone, but the Warp 30 charger certainly is. The Nord guzzles a lot of power, particularly the 5G modem. We started the day with full charge, and by 5:30PM we had around 15 per cent remaining, which is certainly disappointing. The charging speed is where the Nord proves its mettle. A mere 20 minute charge was enough to charge the phone from 15 to 50 per cent.



Bottomline

The OnePlus Nord is a perfectly ordinary smartphone by today's standards, but is extraordinarily smooth and responsive.

However, with devices like the Realme X3 SuperZoom and the Redmi K20 Pro rocking the Snapdragon 855 SoC, the Nord is not the outright choice, but a pragmatic and sensible one. If we have to sum up the experience for the OnePlus Nord, it's a compact smartphone that offers the smoothest smartphone experience in this segment.

—Subhrojit Mallick

SPECIFICATIONS

OPERATING SYSTEM: OxygenOS based on Android 10 | CPU: Qualcomm Snapdragon 765G 5G | GPU: Adreno 620 | RAM: 6GB/8GB/12GB LPDDR4X | STORAGE: 64GB/128GB/256GB UFS2.1 | BATTERY: 4115 mAh | CHARGING: Warp Charge 30T fast charging | REAR CAMERAS: 48MP Sony IMX58 lens (f/1.75), 8MP ultrawide lens (f/2.25), 5MP depth lens, 2MP Macro lens | REAR CAMERA VIDEO: 1080P at 30/60 fps, 4K 30 fps | FRONT CAMERA: 32MP Sony IMX616 lens (f/2.45), 8MP ultrawide lens (f/2.45) | FRONT CAMERA VIDEO: 4K at 30/60 fps, 1080P at 30/60 fps | BLUETOOTH: v5.1 | DISPLAY: 2400x1080 pixels 408ppi, 90Hz refresh rate, 6.44-inches AMOLED | GLASS: Corning Gorilla Glass 5 | WEIGHT: 184g

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